

ranging from sex to finances. Those assurances do help develop strong ties to the coach, but they are also self-defeating when those being coached discover the hard truth that there is no substitute for personal discipline.

I have been doing financial coaching for more than twenty-five years, and sometimes I think I have seen every possible problem and solution. Then someone comes up with an idea no one else has tried. Often when I pray with someone at the beginning of a coaching session, I am not really praying for them—I am praying for myself. I realize that I don't know all the answers, but I know that God does. If I can remember to draw from His wisdom, the persons coming to me for advice are not affected by my good or bad days.

I have coached several people whom I practically adopted. They became so dependent on my input that they literally refused to make a decision without talking to me first. Most coaches have experienced that at one time or another. At first I was flattered and allowed myself to be put in the position of becoming almost a substitute for the Holy Spirit in their lives (although that certainly was not my intent).

Then I discovered that they had become so paralyzed by their own mistakes that they no longer trusted their own judgment. Sometimes that is a predictable but temporary condition. For instance, someone who has suffered a trauma, such as a divorce or death of a spouse, may well need the support of an adviser. But beyond a few weeks (at the very most), that can become a crippling dependency. We all need others to counsel with and confide in, but God must be our permanent source of support.

I say this because I'm sure that some who read this book are depending too much on a particular adviser. A coach is there to guide you and offer alternatives but not to become a stand-in father or mother. Seek the face of God and His wisdom as your primary source of counsel, and you'll never be disappointed. If you find that one of your coaches is giving you advice contrary to God's Word, seek another coach.